

‘I don’t know anything about investing.’ Said with the right toss of the head and eye-roll, the dialogue conveys much more than the words. It says: Money is gross; I am too cool to spend my time thinking about it. It says: I have better things to do than do *baniyagiri* with profit and loss – leave that to the traders. What it actually means: I don’t know anything about investing. I am so afraid of the future that I’m frozen.

This head toss and eye-roll is actually the defence mechanism to convince oneself that one has no option but to continue to live without a money plan. ***What you need to remember is that understanding investing is a one-time fixed cost in terms of your time.*** Once you get it, nobody can take it away from you. Once you get the logic of a financial plan and understand the basics, you can’t get cheated again. It won’t take long. You are a doctor, a lawyer, an engineer, a teacher, an entrepreneur, a homemaker – you are all smart people. You can do this. Remember that it is in the interest of the financial sector to make you believe that you are a money dummy. It just takes common sense and some time to ‘get’ finance.

Once you have talked yourself out of these fears, we can start the investing conversation. The cash flow system already in place in your money box will help you see clearly what you can invest. We’ll find out how much you need to save in the chapter on retirement. For now, let’s just stay with the concept of investing and why we find it so difficult to do. Notice that we’ve begun to discuss investing in [Chapter 6](#) and not [Chapter 1](#).

We’ve been programmed to think about investment products by a commission-driven marketplace. How often has the person offering to solve your financial worries begun with ‘So how much do you have to invest?’ But the answer to how much to invest depends on so many things. It depends on why you want to invest, for how long you want to invest, how comfortable you are with taking a bit of risk to target a higher return.

It depends on how many people you have in your family; it depends on how secure your job is. It depends on what other products you have already in your money box. It depends on whether you are an entrepreneur, a salaried employee or a consultant.